the case of the

TUESDAY GHOST

a sherlock holmes mystery for the modern pipeline

the moral

a key outlives the person who made it.

keys should expire, like milk. write down what each one opens, and when it ends.

> case file for you: is there a key in your system that was last rotated *never*?

(tuesdays were saved. watson brought tacos.)

elementary

holmes didn't guess. he followed the key, and in an old folder he found a note:

"please give each job its own key."
— j. moriarty, 2015

so they did. watson wrote each one down, with the date it ends.

next tuesday, the build passed. everyone got paid.

too fast

"cancel it!" said lestrade, and cancelled moriarty's key himself.

the build passed. then payroll ran. nobody got paid.

the key opened more than one door.

2 a.m., in the fog

the build has failed again. the ops channel lights up like halloween.

holmes (site reliability) is summoned.
watson (compliance) brings tea and her key register. **lestrade** (management) wants an ETA.

"fix it," said lestrade, "or no more tuesdays."

the clues

1. it only ever fails on tuesdays.
2. deploy before lunch in singapore: fine. after lunch: kaboom.
3. the logs rotate into a file called `ghost.log`.
4. ghost.log is completely empty.

"curious," says holmes. "very curious."

the usual suspects

a flaky network? a permissions mix-up? a YAML file cursed by one missing space? holmes rules them out, one by one.

then watson opens her register. one key was last rotated: *never*. it's signed *j. moriarty, 2014*.

moriarty left ten years ago.

the stakeout

tuesday night, they waited, every clock set to the same time.

at **05:07 UTC**, something logged in with moriarty's key. it ate all the memory, then tidied the logs on its way out. that's why `ghost.log` was empty.

the ghost had a key.

cut along the dashes